

Reasoning & Assumptions

Study Guide - Arguments & Sources

1. Learning goal

Evaluate whether a conclusion follows logically from the evidence and identify hidden assumptions an argument depends on.

2. What this skill means

Reasoning is the bridge between evidence and a claim. A weak argument may use real evidence but make a jump that the evidence does not justify. An assumption is an unstated idea that must be true for that jump to work.

3. Do not confuse it with

Do not focus on naming formal fallacies. GED-style reasoning questions are usually about what is wrong in context: overgeneralizing, confusing correlation with cause, using a weak comparison, ignoring alternatives, or assuming a missing condition.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask: "What assumption does the argument depend on?", "What is the flaw in the reasoning?", "Which evidence weakens the conclusion?", or "Which conclusion follows most logically?"

5. Repeatable method

- Write the evidence in one short line.
- Write the conclusion in one short line.
- Ask: what must be true to move from the evidence to that conclusion?
- Look for alternative causes, weak comparisons, missing groups, or certainty jumps.
- Choose the answer that identifies the exact reasoning gap.

6. Worked example

A manager says a booking app will eliminate waiting because restaurants use reservations successfully. The service desk, however, handles many requests whose length cannot be predicted in advance.

Question: What is the main reasoning problem?

Reasoning: The argument assumes a service desk works like a restaurant even though appointment length is much less predictable.

Best answer: The comparison ignores an important difference between the two situations.

7. Common traps

- Attacking the person instead of evaluating the reasoning.
- Choosing an assumption that is possible but not necessary for the argument.
- Calling an argument weak just because you disagree with the conclusion.

8. Diagnostic help

- If your answer describes a personality trait, return to the evidence-to-conclusion link.
- If removing the assumption would not hurt the argument, it is probably not the required assumption.
- If the evidence is true but the conclusion still feels too broad, identify the missing step.

9. Quick check

"Our office should copy Company X's four-day schedule because Company X reported higher morale."

What assumption is built into this reasoning?

Check yourself: That the offices are similar enough, and that the schedule rather than other differences explains the reported morale result.